

Top Secret

Case 001

OPERATION SHADE

A single creator. Four thousand eight hundred messages a month. One person answering them. Your job is to work out what is really being asked.

BRIEFING 01

THE ASSIGNMENT

THE ASK

ONE PRODUCT // 8 HOURS

BUILD ONE WORKING PRODUCT THAT GETS MAYA OUT OF THE REPLY LOOP WITHOUT MAKING HER AUDIENCE FEEL HANDED TO A MACHINE.

DELIVERABLE

A working demo you can show in under a minute. Not a deck.

CHECKPOINTS

16:00 intelligence drop. 17:00 Maya walks in. 20:00 you pitch.

JUDGED ON

Value to a real audience member. Fidelity to Maya’s voice. Use of the evidence. Does it work.

THE TARGET

Maya Rao. Beauty creator. 50K followers. Operating alone.

THE MISSION

Find what is making Maya harder to scale. Build what gets her out of the loop, without making her audience feel like they are talking to a machine.

50K

TOTAL FOLLOWERS

4.8K

DMS / MONTH

70+ hrs

REPLY TIME / MONTH

1

PERSON RUNNING THE BUSINESS

MATERIALS ISSUED

01 A creator dossier

02 Audience evidence

03 Content + product data

04 Private notes + voice note

05 A sealed intelligence drop

STANDING ORDER

You do not need to use an LLM. You do not get extra points for complexity. The winning product is the one that best understands Maya and creates real value for her audience.

BRIEFING 02

SUBJECT FILE

The creator at the centre of the case.

SURVEILLANCE PHOTO

WITHHELD

MAYA RAO

29 // London

35K Instagram 15K TikTok

BEAUTY / SKINCARE

REF SHD-001-SUBJ

VERIFIED

REPUTATION	
Maya is not famous-famous. She is trusted. Her audience follows her because she is specific, honest and willing to say what is not worth buying.	
SUPERPOWER	Taste + judgement
COMMUNITY	High-intent, high-trust
BUSINESS	Affiliate + brand deals + UGC
TEAM	Maya
PET PEEVE	Generic automation
LANGUAGE	Dry, funny, decisive

Assessment: the asset is the judgement, not the follower count.

BRIEFING 03

KNOWN ASSOCIATES

The people behind the DMs. The interesting signals are not all the loud ones.

EMILY / 22

PRICE SENSITIVE

"I trust you, but I am not spending £100 on serum."

Needs confidence within a budget.

PRIYA / 31

SENSITIVE SKIN

"Every time I try something new my face freaks out."

Needs reassurance + compatibility.

SOPHIE / 27

BEAUTY OBSESSIVE

"Forget the brand. What would YOU buy?"

Wants Maya's judgement, not facts.

HANNAH / 24

OVERWHELMED

"There are 500 versions of this. Just tell me."

Needs fewer choices, not more.

GRACE / 33

BUSY

"I have 5 mins. Give me the two things that matter."

Needs fast, practical decisions.

ALEX / 28

SILENT BROWSER

Saves almost everything. Sends almost nothing.

High intent, low visible engagement.

NOTE Six profiles. Only one of them is quiet, and she may be the most valuable.

E-01

INTERCEPTS

24 hours of DM traffic. Most of it looks simple. It is not.

- E-01.1

@ellie.mp

INFO

what shade are u wearing in todays video???
- E-01.2

@gracelee

RECOMMENDATION

i have dry skin + redness and £60. tell me what to buy pls
- E-01.3

@ameliaxo

JUDGEMENT

okay but if u could only keep ONE of these which one
- E-01.4

@sarah

VALUE

is the cloud cream actually worth £38 or am i being influenced
- E-01.5

@jessica

CONTEXT

i already have the night serum. do i need the barrier cream too???
- E-01.6

@niamh

DIAGNOSIS

i dont even know what my skin type is lol
- E-01.7

@olivia

TRUST

i trust you more than Sephora tbh
- E-01.8

@kate

RELATIONSHIP

Maya I have a first date Friday HELP
- E-01.9

@joanna

CONSTRAINT

can you make me a routine but only 2 products bc i will not do 8 steps
- E-01.10

@mia

DELAYED INTENT

I saw the thing you recommended last week. buying it payday
- E-01.11

@lucy

TRANSFER OF TRUST

not a beauty question but what would you do if it was your money?
- E-01.12

@roisin

PERSONALISATION

can you send me the one you would buy if you were me

CLUE E-01

The inbox is noisy. The language underneath it is consistent: *what would Maya do?*

E-02 RECOVERED NOTEBOOK

Messy on purpose. Useful on purpose.

E-02.1

WHAT I ACTUALLY ASK PEOPLE

Skin type?

What are you using now?

What do you hate about it?

Budget?

What finish do you like?

"Do you actually care about skincare or do you just want to look hot tomorrow?"

E-02.2 // THE ROUTING SHE DOES IN HER HEAD

DRY → Cloud Cream + Barrier Oil

OILY → Daily Gel

SENSITIVE → avoid fragrance

REDNESS → Red Reset

shade questions = ask current foundation

E-02.3 // MARGIN NOTE

Need to turn all this into something people can use without me answering 200 questions a day.

E-02.4 // UNRELATED TO-DO LIST

CALL SARAH / SEPTEMBER CAMPAIGN

BUY MORE BROWN LIP LINER

DO NOT RECOMMEND [REDACTED] TO EVERYONE

WHAT THE NOTES REVEAL

Maya already has a mental decision tree. She just has no product that carries it.

E-02.5 // SMALL DETAIL

Her favourite moisturiser is saved in her phone as **the good one**. Her audience has started calling it that too.

E-03

BROADCAST LOG

Reach is loud. Intent is quiet.

E-03.1	3 things I would repurchase with £50	48K views	4.2K likes	1.9K saves	812 comments	
E-03.2	Things I bought because TikTok told me to	29K views	2.1K likes	1.4K saves	496 comments	
E-03.3	My skin has been a nightmare lately	74K views	5.8K likes	3.2K saves	1.1K comments	
E-03.4	Luxury vs drugstore: where should your money go?	51K views	4.4K likes	2.7K saves	702 comments	
E-03.5	My 5-minute morning routine	18K views	1.2K likes	4.6K saves	312 comments	317 affiliate conversions
E-03.6	The product I would NOT rebuy	26K views	1.9K likes	3.1K saves	624 comments	
	Maya earns less, trust earns more					

CLUE E-03

The highest reach post is not the highest commercial signal. Read the behaviour, not the vanity metric.

E-04

INVENTORY // THE SHELF

A product is not the same thing as a recommendation.

REF	PRODUCT	£	TYPE	SKIN	FINISH	MAYA	HER NOTE
E-04.1	Cloud Cream	38	Moisturiser	Dry	Rich	9.2	"My winter skin saviour."
E-04.2	Daily Gel	24	Moisturiser	Oily / Combo	Light	8.1	"Easy. No drama."
E-04.3	Red Reset	32	Serum	Sensitive	Calm	9.5	"For angry skin days."
E-04.4	Night Serum	42	Serum	All	Glow	8.8	"Best for texture."
E-04.5	SPF 50	26	SPF	All	Invisible	9.6	"Non-negotiable."
E-04.6	Glass Drop	62	Serum	All	Dewy	8.1	"Good. Not £62 good."
E-04.7	Soft Clean	22	Cleanser	All	Cream	8.6	"Boring in the best way."
E-04.8	Oil Balm	29	Balm	Dry	Glow	7.7	"Beautiful, but too much for me."
E-04.9	Clear Wash	20	Cleanser	Oily	Foam	8.0	"Great after gym."
E-04.10	Tint Veil	34	Base	All	Skin-like	9.0	"Best on camera."

ONE CONTRADICTION // E-04.6

"Great product. Would not pay £62."

ASSESSMENT

Maya is not a database. Her value is the judgement layered on top of the product.

E-05

MOVEMENT REPORT

What people do after they watch Maya is more revealing than what they say.

E-05.1	E-05.2	E-05.3	E-05.4
38,421	11,804	6,219	1,847
BEAUTY-RELATED COMMENTS	PRODUCT QUESTIONS	"WHAT SHOULD I BUY?" QUESTIONS	MAYA ANSWERED PERSONALLY

E-05.5 // TRACKED JOURNEYS

Rina / 26	Watched 3 videos → saved 2 → visited affiliate link → returned 4 days later → bought.
Megan / 23	Watched "£50" post → sent to friend → friend asked Maya in comments → bought same day.
Alice / 34	Never DM'd → saved 7 posts over 3 weeks → bought Cloud Cream + SPF → returned 19 days later.
Naomi / 28	Asked which serum → got answer → did not buy → returned 6 weeks later after seeing routine content.

OBSERVATION

The visible audience and the valuable audience are not the same thing.

Some ask. Some save. Some share privately. Some wait. Some buy. Some come back. The product opportunity may live between those behaviours.

E-06

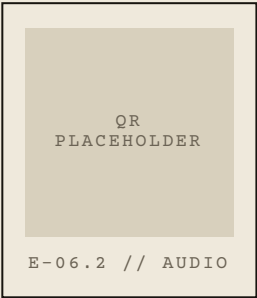
MAYA, UNFILTERED

Scan the case QR to hear the original recording. Transcript below.

E-06.1 // VOICE NOTE00:52



“I genuinely do not want to stop talking to my audience. That is the best part. I just do not want to answer the same question 400 times. People follow me because they trust my taste. I want them to feel like they are still getting my recommendation, even when I am not personally typing the answer.”



E-06.3 // READ BETWEEN THE LINES

/ She is not asking for less relationship.

/ She is asking for leverage.

/ The audience wants judgement, not a catalogue.

/ The product has to preserve trust.

E-07

SEIZED ITEMS

Recovered: one beauty bag. Four things in it do not have an obvious reason for being there.

ITEM PHOTO

E-07.1

BROWN LIP LINER

The shade Maya wears when she has "5 minutes."

ITEM PHOTO

E-07.2

RECEIPT

Three items, one crossed out twice.

ITEM PHOTO

E-07.3

MINI MIRROR

Back says: You are not the user.

ITEM PHOTO

E-07.4

STICKY NOTE

"People do not need more products. They need confidence."

E-08

DISCOUNTED LEADS

A good investigation notices what does not fit.

E-08.1	The obvious answer: build a DM bot.	Too literal. It handles volume, not judgement.
E-08.2	The biggest post: 74K views.	Not the strongest commerce signal.
E-08.3	The most expensive product: £62 serum.	Maya likes it. She would not recommend paying £62.
E-08.4	The noisiest customer: 14-minute voice note.	High emotional demand. Not necessarily high commercial value.
E-08.5	The silent customer: never comments, saves everything, returns later.	Potentially more valuable than the loud customer.

Intelligence Drop

DO NOT OPEN UNTIL 16:00

The case will change. Builders should not see the next sheet until the organiser reveals it. Print this sheet as the outer face of a black envelope.

Sealed

E-09

THE SIGNAL IS SOMEWHERE ELSE

New information. Same target. 90 days of audience behaviour against Maya’s commerce activity.

FINDING // E-09.1

THE CUSTOMERS WHO DM MAYA ARE NOT HER BEST BUYERS

Her highest-value customers are more likely to save, privately share and return later. Many never message her at all.

E-09.2	0-1 DMS	61% of repeat buyers sent no DM before purchase
E-09.3	SAVES	Top-decile savers converted 2.4x more than average
E-09.4	PRIVATE SHARES	41% of high-value buyers first encountered Maya through a share from a friend
E-09.5	TIME	Median purchase lag after first content exposure: 4.6 days

THE QUESTION

The problem may not be “How do we answer more DMs?”

It may be: how do we help someone make a confident decision before they ever need to ask Maya?

E-10

THE HIDDEN AUDIENCE

A sample from the behavioural file released at 16:00.

REF	USER	DM	SAVES	SHARES	RETURN	BUY	LAG	ORDER
E-10.1	Rina	0	8	3	4	YES	4d	£71
E-10.2	Megan	1	2	6	2	YES	1d	£38
E-10.3	Alice	0	7	4	3	YES	7d	£94
E-10.4	Naomi	2	3	0	2	NO	–	–
E-10.5	Tara	0	11	2	5	YES	3d	£122
E-10.6	Liv	4	1	0	1	NO	–	–
E-10.7	Zoe	0	9	5	4	YES	6d	£86
E-10.8	Ella	3	2	1	1	NO	–	–
E-10.9	Mila	0	5	4	3	YES	2d	£64
E-10.10	Nora	1	1	0	1	NO	–	–

BRIEFING 04 // CONTACT

THE JUDGING

At 18:00 the Judges take their stand.

THE RULE

For the demo, don't just tell what you've built - show how it makes their life easier.

01 **WOULD YOU USE THIS?**

02 **WOULD YOU TRUST THIS WITH YOUR AUDIENCE?**

03 **WOULD YOU SHARE THIS?**

04 **WHAT FEELS LIKE WORK?**

05 **WHAT FEELS LIKE YOU?**

DO NOT ASK "Do you like our app?" Ask about the behaviour you observed instead.

EXFILTRATION

Eyes only

THE GETAWAY

90 seconds. Product first. No deck.

30 sec

THE TARGET

What were you stealing?

90 sec

THE HEIST

Show what you built.

60 sec

THE SCORE

What changed? Time, confidence, conversion, trust?

FINAL LINE

"Maya no longer needs to _____ because
_____."

SHIP IT